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SOCIAL

What are the current social factors (like demographics, lifestyles, cultural values, or consumer behavior) relevant to your project topic? Think globally, nationally, and locally.

Demographics: Post-grad students (20s)

US Lifestyles (different archetypes for post-grad students):

- Career-driven, climbing the ladder
- Grad school
- Traveling

Common questions that spark anxiety:

- "What are your plans post college? Who are you? What do you want to do?"
- cultural pressures specifically with the US

What SOURCE did this come from? (be specific)

Social media, personal experience

US American work culture:
<https://www.smithsonianmag.com/history/the-roots-of-us-work-culture-and-why-the-american-dream-is-so-difficult-to-achieve-today-180985767/>

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Social Factors that cause anxiety

- moving to a new place -- not knowing anyone
- state of the world
- employment/unemployment
- student loans
- no routine/structure (ex: no class schedule, no feasible ways to measure success like a grade)

College graduates have an easier time with connection

What SOURCE did this come from? (be specific)

Healthline (<https://www.healthline.com/health/depression/post-grad-depression#how-to-cope>)

Article: College Graduates Have More Important Social Connections With Others

<https://www.pyoreducationinsights.com/blog/2024/9/6/omzdy4nembslmc4zes64d12st0jss>

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TECHNOLOGICAL

What are the technological enablers, disrupters, or trends relative to your project topic? Think globally, nationally, and locally.

Social media platforms (more social media usage --> correlated w/ more loneliness)

- Instagram
- Facebook
- Tik Tok

Forums

- Reddit
- Discord

Side Note: Perhaps comparison is the problem? People are too focused on what people put out on social media

What SOURCE did this come from? (be specific)

<https://news.oregonstate.edu/news/loneliness-us-adults-linked-amount-frequency-social-media-use> -- article on social media & loneliness correlation

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TECHNOLOGICAL

What are the technological enablers, disrupters, or trends relative to your project topic? Think globally, nationally, and locally.

GenAI & Zoom

- less face to face connection especially post COVID 19
- more prominent for remote work, less ability to make in-person connections
- people using GenAI as therapy?? pros and cons to this *more in the article

What SOURCE did this come from? (be specific)

<https://pmc.ncbi.nlm.nih.gov/articles/PM9338168/> -- Virtual social interaction and loneliness among emerging adults amid the COVID-19 pandemic

<https://hai.stanford.edu/news/exploring-the-dangers-of-ai-in-mental-health-care> -- dangers of AI in mental health

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ECONOMIC

What economic trends or shifts have an impact in your project topic? Think globally, nationally, and locally.

- Socioeconomic backgrounds of people influence post-grad plans
 - some people need to find a post-grad job (paying off loans, independent, etc.)
 - some people are able to return to their homes and rely on family's income
- testimonial of this found below!

What **SOURCE** did this come from? (be specific)

<https://www.businessinsider.com/recently-graduated-college-incredibly-lonely-struggling-adjust-2024-1> -- title: "I recently graduated college and loneliness is one of the most unexpected parts of post-grad life. It makes it difficult to adjust"

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ECONOMIC

What economic trends or shifts have an impact in your project topic? Think globally, nationally, and locally.

- 38% of students were never taught how to manage their finances, while 35% were taught by a parent or family member.
- Male students are far more likely than female students to say they are confident in budgeting their money (75% vs. 64%) and their knowledge of how student loans work (61% vs. 51%).
- Almost half (49%) of students overall say they often felt stressed about money in the last month.

What **SOURCE** did this come from? (be specific)

<https://collegepulse.com/blog/college-students-manage-personal-finances-money> -- "4 in 10 College Students Weren't Taught How to Manage their Finances"

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ENVIRONMENTAL

What are emerging environmental trends or drivers relative to your project topic? Think globally, nationally, and locally.

- Spending more time in nature increases more social connection
- Increased social media use leads to worse mental health and less time spent outdoors

What **SOURCE** did this come from? (be specific)

<https://www.sciencedirect.com/science/article/pii/S0272494424001166> -- Shared time in nature increases feelings of social connection amongst university students

<https://pmc.ncbi.nlm.nih.gov/articles/PMC10010124/> -- The Association Between Screen Time and Outdoor Time on Adolescent Mental Health and Academic Performance

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ENVIRONMENTAL

What are emerging environmental trends or drivers relative to your project topic? Think globally, nationally, and locally.

- Excessive use of Generative AI such as Chat GPT, Gemini, etc. has severe environmental effects
 - (Thought process: people are using GenAI in supplement of therapy use)
 - Effects --> increased electricity demand and water consumption

What **SOURCE** did this come from? (be specific)

<https://news.mit.edu/2025/explained-generative-ai-environmental-impact-0117> -- Explained: Generative AI's environmental impact

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POLITICAL

What political trends or shifts impact your project topic? Think globally, nationally, and locally.

- Big social media platforms are able to push their own political agendas
 - "Social networks such as Twitter, Facebook, and Google hold the potential to alter civic engagement"

What **SOURCE** did this come from? (be specific)

<https://pmc.ncbi.nlm.nih.gov/articles/PMC7343248/> -- Social Media Effects: Hijacking Democracy and Civility in Civic Engagement

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POLITICAL

What political trends or shifts impact your project topic? Think globally, nationally, and locally.

- Platforms such as Twitter, Instagram, Facebook, etc. have led to more people becoming polarized
 - From Google AI: The correlation between polarized politics and loneliness is widely supported by research, showing that rising political division can contribute to social isolation, and, conversely, loneliness can fuel political tribalism. This relationship is part of a negative feedback loop that impacts individual well-being and civic life.

What **SOURCE** did this come from? (be specific)

From Google's AI generated answer!

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WILD CARD

Is there anything else that is interesting relative to your project topic? Think globally, nationally, and locally.

- Job statistics influencing post-grad anxiety
 - A 2024 report found that 52% of four-year college graduates are underemployed a year after graduation, and this number remains high at 45% a decade later

What **SOURCE** did this come from? (be specific)

From Google's AI generated answer!

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WILD CARD

Is there anything else that is interesting relative to your project topic? Think globally, nationally, and locally.

- Post grad statistics influencing post-grad anxiety
 - 34% of respondents didn't have a plan
 - 41% didn't even have a job lined up.
 - 17% who attended college said they had no plans after senior year

What **SOURCE** did this come from? (be specific)

<https://nypost.com/2022/06/02/one-third-of-americans-admit-no-life-plans-after-graduating/> -- One-third of Americans admit they had no life plan after graduating school

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